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Actual or default? The CBAM data decision for Turkish metal exporters

Why the emissions question has moved from your EU buyer's compliance desk into your commercial negotiation.

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Executive summary

1. The definitive CBAM regime has applied since 1 January 2026. EU importers bringing in more than 50 tonnes of covered goods a year must be authorised CBAM declarants, and the first annual declaration covering 2026 imports falls in 2027.
2. For a Turkish iron, steel or aluminium supplier, the practical question is no longer whether CBAM applies. It is whether to give EU buyers verified actual emissions data, or let them rely on default values. That is a commercial decision with a data cost, not a reporting chore.
3. Actual values are not automatically cheaper for anyone. The answer depends on the production route, the quality of plant data, the cost of independent verification, and how the contract shares the CBAM cost between buyer and supplier.

What has changed

CBAM moved from a reporting-only transition into its definitive phase on 1 January 2026. Importers of covered goods such as iron and steel, aluminium, cement and fertilisers now need authorised declarant status once their annual imports pass the 50-tonne threshold, and they will buy and surrender CBAM certificates for the embedded emissions of what they import.

Through the autumn of 2026 the European Commission has been publishing implementation material: resources and training for verifiers, an implementation webinar, and quarterly certificate price information. None of this is new law, but it shows the regime is moving from preparation to operation.

Two details matter for Turkish suppliers. First, the 50-tonne threshold is assessed at the level of the EU importer’s annual imports, not on the supplier’s total exports. Second, where actual emissions are used instead of default values, they must be verified by an accredited verifier that is independent of whoever prepared the data.

At home, Türkiye is building its own emissions trading system, currently in a pilot phase, and sustainability reporting standards are widening disclosure duties. Emissions data built carefully once can serve several of these purposes.

The decision behind the requirement

Default values are set conservatively. A plant that is cleaner than the default for its product can therefore look worse on paper than it is, and its EU buyer pays for the difference. Actual values

close that gap, but only if the data behind them are complete, traceable and verifiable.

That turns emissions data into a pricing variable. A buyer that bears the certificate cost has a reason to prefer suppliers with credible actual values, and may ask for them as a condition of continued supply. A supplier with good data may be able to defend volume or price. A supplier with weak data may spend money proving a number that turns out no better than the default.

The sound question is therefore not ‘how do we comply?’ but ‘for which products and buyers does credible actual data change the commercial outcome, and what will it cost us to produce it every period?’

Five common misreadings

“Our CBAM cost is simply embedded emissions times the carbon price.” It is not. Adjustments, including those linked to free allocation in the EU and carbon prices already paid in the country of origin, mean simple multiplication usually overstates the figure and misleads the negotiation.

“Actual values always save money.” Only where the plant is genuinely better than the default and the data and verification costs are proportionate to the volume involved.

“The 50-tonne threshold is about our exports.” It is about each importer’s annual imports. Some of your smaller EU customers may fall outside the obligation entirely; your larger ones will not.

“Our consultant can verify the data.” Preparing data and verifying it are separate roles. Mixing them undermines the verification your buyer depends on.

“This is a one-off file.” Buyers need emissions data for each period and product route. The real decision is whether to build a repeatable routine, not whether to produce one spreadsheet.

Questions for the leadership team

1. Which of our EU customers are above the threshold, and which have asked or will ask for actual data?
2. Which products and production routes carry most of our EU volume?
3. Is our installation boundary clear, and are production routes separated in our records?
4. Where do energy, production and precursor data sit today, and who owns each source?
5. What would independent verification cost relative to the volume it would cover?
6. How do our contracts allocate CBAM cost, and is that open to renegotiation?
7. Do our precursor suppliers provide emissions data we can rely on?
8. Who in our business owns the CBAM conversation with buyers?

What a good first step produces

A useful first step is narrow: one product, one EU buyer relationship. It should leave the leadership team with a clear view of what that buyer needs, an honest picture of the data gaps, a comparison of actual and default outcomes, and a go or no-go on building a recurring routine.

Ganrich Advisory runs this as a focused readiness review and coordinates with independent verifiers and customs specialists where needed. We share the working method in a conversation rather than in print, because it is adapted to each plant.

Start a conversation

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About this paper. This paper reflects official sources checked on 21–23 October 2026. It is general information, not legal, customs, tax or engineering advice. Rules, thresholds and dates change; confirm them against official sources before acting. It describes no client work or results.

Sources: European Commission, Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism: taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/carbon-border-adjustment-mechanism_en · European Commission, CBAM definitive regime: taxation-customs.ec.europa.eu/carbon-border-adjustment-mechanism/cbam-definitive-regime_en

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